

Zion Suzuki

In the summer of 2023, Japanese goalkeeper Zion Suzuki, then 20, turned down an offer to join Manchester United as a second-choice keeper.

While many players would have seized the opportunity, Suzuki — with an eye on the next World Cup — prioritised playing time, opting instead for a move to Belgian Pro League club Sint-Truiden before joining Italian side Parma the following season.

The decision has paid dividends. He has since cemented his place between the sticks for Asia's top-ranked side, which also became the first team apart from the hosts to secure qualification for the

tournament.

He was just 16 years and five months old when he signed his first professional contract with Japanese side Urawa Red Diamonds, becoming the youngest to do so. Over four years at the club, he trained under club legend Shusaku Nishikawa, refining his game into that of a modern, ball-playing goalkeeper.

In 10 appearances in the World Cup qualifiers, Suzuki kept nine clean sheets, conceding just once. What sets the 23-year-old apart is not just his shot-stopping, but his ability to launch attacks from deep. For a team like Japan that thrives on fast breaks and quick movement, Suzuki's distribution could prove to be decisive.

JAPAN

Age - 23

Club - Parma

Int. caps - 23

